again, I do understand exactly what she means. When I am passed Lola, something washes over me. Our lives are new, not entirely our own any more. Rather than it provoking panic, I feel very calm. It seems extremely natural to be holding Lola, and a side of me which is not often encouraged – a gentleness, a caring, a nurturing of something else – is opened.

When I have to leave again two weeks later, I am devastated. I don't want to go. It's the first time I've ever not wanted to leave to play cricket for England. Eventually I have to, and join the first series under new captain and coach, Andrew Strauss and Andy Flower, against the West Indies. We are beaten – shocked by some spells of inspired bowling by Jerome Taylor – and when I come home, I find that Daniella, having never held a child before we had one, has developed a hard-fought routine with Lola. I join in, trying not to break their patterns, and we spend every day driving around endlessly, listening to Baby Einstein nursery rhymes, speaking as quietly as we can to send Lola off to sleep. It's the only way she will nod off. It takes hours, and when that doesn't work, we sing to her until it does.